



the President by the Constitution. His successor, S. Radhakrishnan, an Oxford don, is best known as the man who introduced the views of western idealist philosophers in India. Radhakrishnan and Zakir Husain both acquitted themselves with dignity because they were more scholars than politicians. After them came the decline with the trend of appointing politicians as presidents started by Indira Gandhi.

During the 1960s, Shankar Dayal Sharma became President as the reward for supporting Indira's quest for leadership of the Congress. His only notable contribution was that during his last year as President, he swore in three prime ministers. The nadir came with Fakhruddin Ali Ahmed (1974-77), who was roused from his sleep at the dead of night to sign the proclamation declaring Emergency rule by prime minister Indira on June 25-26, 1975. He didn't even bother to check whether

the measure had cabinet approval. All his successors were hardcore politicians, with V.V. Giri (1969-74) and N. Sanjeeva Reddy (1977-82) playing a factional role in the break-up of the Congress. Reddy was sidelined by Indira for his role in splitting the party but had his revenge when she lost the 1977 elections and her opponents, led by Morarji Desai, won famously and installed Reddy as President. His successor, Giani Zail Singh (1982-87), took presidential intervention to new heights. After declaring publicly that he wouldn't mind sweeping the floor if the prime minister (Indira) wanted him to do so, he fell out with Rajiv Gandhi, Indira's successor as prime minister, and was involved in a conspiracy to topple him. Zail Singh's tenure didn't bring any glory to the office of the president, and Narayanan (1997-2002), the first Dalit President, proved ineffective and effete.

In contrast, Kalam, a non-politician, brought the much-needed dignity and stature to the presidency, his unprecedented popularity among the

SURPRISE: Vajpayee named Kalam for President and had no regrets

masses being ample evidence. A people's president for sure, he was also the most unconventional President we have had. During his presidency, attitudes changed in the Rashtrapati Bhavan. Protocol was reduced to an executive term. The President's office staffers were free to call upon him whenever they had to discuss an issue or two. "If you can pick up the phone and speak, why can't you meet me in person?" Kalam used to ask his officials. He told his support team that hierarchy was irrelevant in the new world of communication systems. He would dial mobile numbers of his aides directly without going through the telephone operator at Raisina Hill. Moreover, how many presidents have opted, at an age of 74, to fly in a supersonic fighter jet or experience the depths of the ocean in a submarine?

Kalam's greatest legacy remains, however, the manner in which he inspired the young and became their ultimate role model. In fact, post-retirement from the country's top job, Kalam had already chalked out an itinerary that would keep him busy teaching students. He will be a visiting professor at five universities—the Anna University in Chennai, the Gandhigram Rural Institute in Madurai, the IIT in

“He gave a new vision of ACCOUNTABILITY to the HIGHEST OFFICE of the country.”

AMIT MITRA, SECRETARY-GENERAL, FICCI